

## BONUS 2

# Belly-Slimming Pilates at Home

Pilates is a workout of slow, controlled movements that mainly strengthens the **center of the body** — the belly and back area. With no equipment, no impact and without leaving home, it is perfect to go with the diet and speed up results. All you need is a mat or a towel on the floor.

### WHY IT HELPS FLATTEN THE BELLY

- It strengthens the **deep abdominal muscle**, which works like a natural corset and holds the belly in.
- It improves **posture** — and standing taller already makes the belly look visibly flatter.
- It defines the **waist** by working the side muscles.
- It is **low impact**: gentle on the joints, ideal for all ages.

### AN IMPORTANT TRUTH

No exercise burns fat only on the belly — that does not exist. Fat leaves the whole body, and what drives that loss is your **diet**. Pilates strengthens, defines and improves posture; together with the book's recipes, it is the combination that truly slims the belly. Consistency is everything.

**How to use it:** do it **3 to 4 times a week**, 15 to 20 minutes. Wear comfortable clothes, train on an empty stomach or at least 1 hour after eating, and **always breathe** (never hold your breath). Start with the easier variations noted in each exercise and progress over time. If you feel sharp pain, stop.

# THE 12 EXERCISES

Do them in order, respecting your breathing and your limit. Each exercise has the focus, the number of reps, the step by step and an easier variation when there is one.

## WEEKLY PLAN

Choose 3 to 4 days (for example **Monday, Wednesday and Friday**) and do the full sequence of the 12 exercises in the order they appear.

The order is already thought out: it starts with the **warm-up** (1 and 2), goes through the **belly** exercises (3 to 10), strengthens the **back** (11) and ends with the **stretch** (12). Never skip the warm-up or the stretch.

|    |                                         |                             |
|----|-----------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| 1  | Pilates Breathing (Activating the Core) | 5 breaths                   |
| 2  | Pelvic Tilt                             | 2 sets of 10                |
| 3  | The Hundred                             | 1 set (count to 100)        |
| 4  | Alternating Leg Lift                    | 2 sets of 12                |
| 5  | Small Crunch (Chest Lift)               | 3 sets of 12                |
| 6  | Front Plank                             | 3 times, hold 20–40 s       |
| 7  | Side Plank                              | 2 times each side, 15–30 s  |
| 8  | Glute Bridge                            | 3 sets of 12                |
| 9  | Spine Roll Up                           | 2 sets of 8                 |
| 10 | Bicycle Crunch                          | 3 sets of 20 (10 each side) |
| 11 | Superman (Back Extension)               | 3 sets of 10                |
| 12 | Final Stretch                           | Hold 30 s each              |

# Pilates Breathing (Activating the Core)

First of all, learn to switch on the core from the inside — that is what makes Pilates work and the belly firmer.

**Beginner**

LEVEL

**5 breaths**

SETS

**2 min**

TIME

## FOCUS

Learning to contract the deep abdominals — the base of every exercise.

## HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your back, knees bent and feet flat on the floor, hip-width apart. Let your arms rest by your sides.
- 2 Place your hands on your belly. Breathe in through your nose, filling your belly like a balloon.
- 3 Breathe out slowly through your mouth and, at the same time, pull your navel in toward your spine, as if closing the zipper of tight pants.
- 4 Hold that contraction for 3 seconds, feeling the belly firm, and relax.
- 5 Repeat 5 times, always breathing out and pulling the navel in.

## BREATHING

Breathe in through your nose filling the belly; breathe out through your mouth emptying and contracting the core. Never hold your breath.

**TIP**

This 'pull the navel in' is the secret of Pilates. You will use this same contraction in every other exercise — it is what works the deepest belly muscle, the one that holds everything in place and slims the waist.

# Pelvic Tilt

A small, gentle movement that loosens the lower back and wakes up the lower belly.



**Beginner**  
LEVEL

**2 sets of 10**  
SETS

**3 min**  
TIME

## FOCUS

Warming up the spine and activating the lower belly.

## HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Stay lying on your back, knees bent and feet on the floor.
- 2 Breathe out and pull your navel in, tilting your pelvis slightly backward so your lower back presses fully into the floor.
- 3 Breathe in and return slowly, leaving a small gap between your lower back and the floor.
- 4 Do the movement very slowly, as if drawing with your hips, without forcing.
- 5 Repeat 10 times, rest and do another set of 10.

## BREATHING

Breathe out as your lower back presses into the floor; breathe in as you return. The movement follows the breath.

## TIP

It is a perfect warm-up for anyone with a sensitive lower back. The movement is short on purpose — the belly contraction is in charge, not the back's strength.

# The Hundred

The classic that warms up the whole body and makes the core burn — gently, but it burns.



**Intermediate**  
LEVEL

**1 set**  
**(count to 100)**  
SETS

**3 min**  
TIME

## FOCUS

The most famous Pilates exercise for the whole belly.

## HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your back, bend your knees and lift your legs until they are bent at 90 degrees (shins parallel to the floor), as if sitting in an upside-down chair.
- 2 Breathe out, pull your navel in and lift your head and shoulders slightly off the floor, looking at your belly. Extend your arms straight beside your body, a hand's width above the floor.
- 3 Start swinging your arms up and down, with short, firm movements, as if tapping the water.
- 4 Count five swings while you breathe in and five while you breathe out.
- 5 Continue until you complete 100 swings (or stop earlier if you tire). Then lower your head and legs and rest.

## BREATHING

Breathe in for 5 swings and out for 5 swings, without stopping the arm pumping.

**TIP**

Easier variation: keep your feet on the floor and just lift your head and shoulders. Start with 30 or 50 swings and build up to 100 over time.

# Alternating Leg Lift

A controlled movement that works exactly that lower belly area, the most stubborn one.

**Beginner**

LEVEL

**2 sets of 12**

SETS

**3 min**

TIME

**FOCUS**

Lower belly and movement control.

**HOW TO DO IT**

- 1 Lie on your back, knees bent and feet flat on the floor. Keep your lower back pressed into the floor the whole time.
- 2 Breathe out, pull your navel in and lift one foot off the floor, bringing the knee toward your belly until the thigh is upright (90 degrees).
- 3 Breathe in and lower the foot slowly until it touches the floor again, with control.
- 4 Alternate: now lift the other leg the same way.
- 5 Do 12 times with each leg, keeping the belly always contracted. Rest and repeat the set.

**BREATHING**

Breathe out as you lift the leg; breathe in as you lower it. The core stays firm the whole time.

**TIP**

What matters is not speed, it is control: the slower you lower the leg, the more the belly works. If you feel your lower back arch and leave the floor, lift the leg less.



# Small Crunch (Chest Lift)

The usual crunch, but done with Pilates control — it rises a little and works a lot.



**Beginner**  
LEVEL

**3 sets of 12**  
SETS

**4 min**  
TIME

## FOCUS

Upper and middle belly.

## HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your back, knees bent and feet on the floor. Cross your arms over your chest or rest your hands behind your head, without pulling your neck.
- 2 Breathe out, pull your navel in and curl your torso up, lifting your head and shoulders off the floor, as if bringing your ribs toward your hips.
- 3 Rise only until the tips of your shoulder blades leave the floor (you do not need to sit up). Hold 1 second at the top.
- 4 Breathe in and lower slowly, rolling your spine back to the floor, vertebra by vertebra.
- 5 Repeat 12 times, rest and do 3 sets in total.

## BREATHING

Breathe out as you rise (that is when the belly contracts most); breathe in as you lower.

## TIP

Do not pull your neck with your hands — your gaze goes to your belly and your chin stays away from your chest, with room for an orange. It is the belly that lifts the body, not the neck.

# Front Plank

Still, but powerful: holding the plank strengthens the whole belly and back at once.



**Intermediate**  
LEVEL

**3 times,**  
**hold 20–**  
**40 s**  
SETS

**4 min**  
TIME

## FOCUS

The whole belly, lower back and posture — the most complete core exercise.

## HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie face down and rest your forearms on the floor, elbows under your shoulders. Your hands are in front.
- 2 Extend your legs back and rest the balls of your feet on the floor.
- 3 Breathe out, pull your navel in and lift your body, keeping it straight like a board, from heels to head.
- 4 Keep your hips in line with your body — not lifted like a hill, not sagging toward the floor. Look at the floor so you do not strain your neck.
- 5 Hold for 20 to 40 seconds, breathing normally. Lower, rest and repeat 3 times.

## BREATHING

Keep breathing normally and slowly throughout the plank. Do not hold your breath.

## TIP

Easier variation: rest your knees on the floor (knee plank). Start by holding 15 seconds and build up gradually. If your lower back hurts, it is a sign your hips sagged — lift them a little.

# Side Plank

It is the exercise that shapes the side of the belly and defines the waist.



**Intermediate**  
LEVEL

**2 times  
each side,  
15–30 s**  
SETS

**4 min**  
TIME

## FOCUS

The side belly muscles (obliques) — slims the waist.

## HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your side, body straight. Rest your bottom forearm on the floor, elbow under your shoulder.
- 2 Stack one leg on top of the other (one foot on the other).
- 3 Breathe out, pull your navel in and lift your hips off the floor, keeping your body straight and supported only on your forearm and the side of your foot.
- 4 Extend the top arm toward the ceiling or rest the hand on your waist. Hold for 15 to 30 seconds.
- 5 Lower with control, turn to the other side and repeat. Do 2 times on each side.

## BREATHING

Breathe normally and slowly while holding the position.

## TIP

Easier variation: bend your knees and rest the lower part of your legs on the floor, lifting only your hips. The waist works the most here — hold firm.

# Glute Bridge

It lifts the backside, strengthens the belly from behind and even improves posture.



**Beginner**  
LEVEL

**3 sets of 12**  
SETS

**3 min**  
TIME

## FOCUS

Glutes, back of the thighs and belly — and it relieves the lower back.

## HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your back, knees bent and feet flat on the floor, hip-width apart. Arms by your sides.
- 2 Breathe out, pull your navel in and lift your hips off the floor, squeezing your glutes, until your body forms a straight line from knees to shoulders.
- 3 Hold 2 seconds at the top, keeping your glutes and belly firm.
- 4 Breathe in and lower your hips slowly, rolling your spine back to the floor, vertebra by vertebra.
- 5 Repeat 12 times, do 3 sets.

## BREATHING

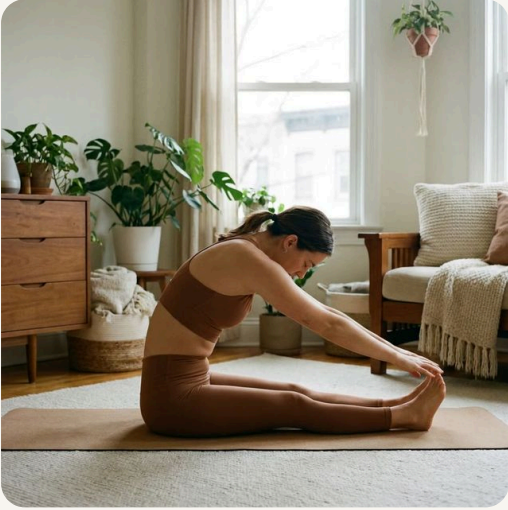
Breathe out as you lift the hips; breathe in as you lower.

## TIP

Rise by squeezing your glutes well, not by pushing your lower back. It is one of the few exercises that strengthens the belly and also relieves back pain — great for anyone who sits all day.

# Spine Roll Up

Sitting up and lying down by slowly rolling the spine — it looks simple, but the belly does all the work.



**Intermediate**  
LEVEL

**2 sets of 8**  
SETS

**4 min**  
TIME

## FOCUS

The whole belly and spine flexibility.

## HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your back with legs extended and arms stretched overhead, behind your head.
- 2 Breathe in and bring your arms forward, pointing at the ceiling.
- 3 Breathe out, pull your navel in and start to sit up very slowly, rolling your spine: first your head, then your shoulders, your back, until you are sitting and reaching your feet with your hands.
- 4 Breathe in at the top and, breathing out, lower the same way slowly, rolling your spine back to the floor, vertebra by vertebra.
- 5 Repeat 8 times, with maximum control. Do 2 sets.

## BREATHING

Breathe out as you rise and as you lower (that is when the belly works); breathe in on the pauses.

**TIP**

Easier variation: bend your knees a little and, if needed, give a small push with your arms. What matters is rising and lowering slowly — it is the belly that does the work, not the neck or arms.

# Bicycle Crunch

The pedaling movement that shapes the sides of the belly and lifts your heart rate a little.



**Intermediate**  
LEVEL

**3 sets of  
20 (10  
each side)**  
SETS

**4 min**  
TIME

## FOCUS

The obliques (side belly) and the whole belly.

## HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your back, hands behind your head (without pulling your neck). Lift your legs with knees bent at 90 degrees.
- 2 Breathe out, pull your navel in and lift your head and shoulders off the floor.
- 3 Rotate your torso, bringing your right elbow toward your left knee, while extending your right leg forward.
- 4 Return to the center and do the other side: left elbow toward the right knee, extending the left leg.
- 5 Keep alternating, as if slowly pedaling a bicycle. Do 20 in total (10 each side), 3 sets.

## BREATHING

Breathe out with each torso rotation; breathe in as you pass through the center.

## TIP

Do it slowly and with control, not in a rush — the torso rotation is what works the side of the belly. The further you extend the leg away, the harder and more effective it gets.



# Superman (Back Extension)

After so many crunches, this one strengthens the back and improves posture — which already makes the belly look flatter.

**Beginner**

LEVEL

**3 sets of 10**

SETS

**3 min**

TIME

## FOCUS

Back and posture — it balances the body and makes the belly look flatter when standing.

## HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie face down (belly down), with your arms extended forward and your legs stretched back.
- 2 Breathe out, pull your navel in slightly and lift your arms, chest and legs off the floor at the same time, a few inches, like Superman flying.
- 3 Hold 2 seconds at the top, looking at the floor so you do not strain your neck.
- 4 Breathe in and lower slowly, relaxing.
- 5 Repeat 10 times, do 3 sets.

## BREATHING

Breathe out as you lift; breathe in as you lower. A smooth movement, with no jerks.

## TIP

You do not need to lift high — a few inches already work the back. Strengthening the back is essential: a strong back holds you upright, and good posture alone already makes the belly look smaller.



# Final Stretch

To finish, a pleasant stretch that relaxes the belly and back you just worked.

**All levels**

LEVEL

**Hold 30 s****each**

SETS

**3 min**

TIME

**FOCUS**

Relaxing the spine and belly after the workout.

**HOW TO DO IT**

- 1 Get on all fours (hands and knees on the floor). Sit your backside onto your heels and extend your arms forward, resting your torso over your thighs (resting pose). Bring your forehead to the floor and breathe deeply for 30 seconds.
- 2 Return to lying on your back. Hug one knee at a time, pulling it toward your chest, and hold 30 seconds each side — this relaxes the lower back.
- 3 Finally, lying on your back with arms open, let both knees drop slowly to one side and then the other, gently rotating the spine, 30 seconds each side.
- 4 Breathe deeply throughout the stretch, without rushing.
- 5 Get up slowly when you finish.

**BREATHING**

Breathe deeply and slowly, breathing out with each stretch and letting the body relax a bit more.

**TIP**

Never skip the stretch: it relaxes the muscles that worked, prevents next-day soreness and improves flexibility. It is the moment to feel your body and close the workout in peace.